

CLA Brand & Design Language OS v1

Working Draft

This is the cumulative master document. Every approved section is preserved in full. Approved sections are considered frozen unless the project owner explicitly requests a revision.

Section 1 - Brand Personality

STATUS: APPROVED

Core Personality

- Elegant
- Minimal
- Vibrant

Design Interpretation

- Elegant through craftsmanship and restraint.
- Minimal through simplicity, clarity, and intentional spacing.
- Vibrant through carefully chosen color, photography, and moments of energy - never through clutter.

Section 2 - Visual Direction

STATUS: APPROVED

Primary Direction

- Apple-level product quality.
- Modern premium church.

Visual Direction Rules

- The website must communicate premium craftsmanship.
- The design must feel clean, intentional, and professionally executed.
- The website should be modern without chasing short-lived trends.
- The design should feel warm and welcoming without becoming casual or childish.
- Every page should feel timeless rather than fashionable.
- Every page should look as though it was designed by the same world-class team.
- The website should point people back to Jesus through clarity, order, and excellence rather than distraction.

Section 3 - Official Color System

STATUS: APPROVED

Primary Brand Color

- Royal Blue.

Dark Foundation Color

- Dark Navy.

Primary Backgrounds

- Pure White.
- Warm Off-White / Ivory.

Accent Colors

- Gold - secondary accent color, used sparingly to highlight important elements.
- Orange - supporting accent color used throughout the website where appropriate and more prominently for Kids, Events, and Seasonal pages.

Gradients

- Gradients are part of the CLA design language.
- They may be used throughout the website when they clearly improve the design.
- They must remain elegant, premium, and restrained.
- They must never overpower the content.

Page and Ministry Accent Colors

- Every major page or ministry may have its own accent color.
- Accent colors may change, but Royal Blue remains the dominant CLA identity color.
- Typography, spacing, navigation, buttons, cards, radius, and motion must keep every page unmistakably CLA.

Approved Examples

- Home - Royal Blue.
- Kids - Orange, Yellow, Blue, and Red.
- Women - Pink with Gold accents.
- Youth - Vibrant Blue.
- MTC - Royal Blue, Dark Navy, White, and restrained Gold.
- Events - Flexible accent palette within the CLA system.

Section 4 - Typography

STATUS: APPROVED

Typography Direction

- A combination of Apple-inspired clean modern typography and elegant editorial typography.

Font System

- Two font families by default: one display font and one body font.
- A third font may be used only for special campaigns, seasonal pages, or unique approved experiences.

Headings

- Bold and commanding.
- Large, confident, and immediately recognizable.
- Never thin, weak, or difficult to read.

Body Text

- Neutral and highly readable.
- Never decorative.
- Optimized for comfortable reading.
- Accessibility and contrast always matter.

Hierarchy

- Very strong hierarchy.
- H1 clearly dominates.
- H2 clearly separates major sections.
- H3 organizes supporting content.
- Body text remains calm and readable.

Alignment

- Mixed alignment.
- Left-aligned for reading-heavy sections.
- Centered for Hero sections, major CTAs, and selected feature sections.
- Alignment must support composition and readability, never be random.

Buttons

- Apple-style rounded corners.
- Premium, modern, and consistent.
- Comfortable touch targets.

White Space

- Generous.
- White space is a design element, not empty space.
- It creates clarity, hierarchy, elegance, and a premium feel.

Typography Motion

- Moderate, smooth, and intentional.
- Motion should enhance the experience without distracting.

Typography Color

- Mostly solid colors.
- Gradient typography is not part of the normal design language.

Section 5 - Photography

STATUS: APPROVED

Primary Photography Style

- Authentic real moments.
- Real worship.
- Real prayer.
- Real people.
- Never staged.
- Never stock-photo looking.

Photography Tone

- Bright and vibrant for joy, children, families, community, and events.
- Natural and realistic for everyday church life.
- Dark and dramatic for worship, prayer, Scripture, and reflective moments.
- The tone must match the story being told.

Photography Layout

- Balanced use of full-width immersive photography and contained photography.

- The layout must support the story rather than follow one rigid rule.

People in Photography

- Balanced use of close emotional portraits and wide environmental storytelling.
- Balanced representation of pastors, members, families, children, volunteers, worship, prayer, and community.

Image Orientation

- Use a balanced mix of landscape and portrait photography.
- Display each image in its natural orientation whenever possible.
- Never force portrait images into landscape crops.
- Never force landscape images into portrait crops.
- Cropping must preserve faces, hands, subjects, and composition.

Editing Style

- Balanced mix of natural and cinematic editing.
- Editing must support the story and keep colors believable.
- Never over-edit.

Images Per Section

- Default to one strong image per section.
- Additional images are used only when they clearly improve the story.
- Quality is more important than quantity.

Decorative Effects

- Minimal only.
- Overlays, glows, frames, and filters may improve readability but must never become the focus.
- Authenticity comes before decoration.

Editorial Overlap

- Allowed occasionally when it clearly improves the composition.
- Never used only for decoration.

Consistency

- One recognizable CLA photography style across the website.
- Pages may adapt tone slightly when the story requires it, but must still feel like CLA.

Hero Photography

- Every major page begins with a signature hero photograph.
- Hero photography should immediately communicate the page purpose.
- Hero images must be professionally composed and optimized for desktop and mobile.
- Decorative graphics should not replace hero photography.

Section 6 - Layout & White Space

STATUS: APPROVED

Overall Layout

- Balanced.
- Spacious without becoming empty.
- Practical without becoming dense.

Content Width

- Medium, balanced content container.
- Wide enough to feel modern and narrow enough for comfortable reading.

Section Spacing

- Balanced and consistent.
- Enough breathing room for clarity without making pages feel empty.

Corner Style

- Large Apple-inspired rounded corners are a defining part of the CLA identity.
- Radius values must come from the shared design system.

Composition

- Balanced mix of symmetrical and asymmetrical layouts.
- Symmetry provides clarity.
- Asymmetry creates intentional editorial interest.

Cards

- Cards are a core part of the CLA design language.
- Cards may be used throughout the website.
- Every card must follow the same component system.

Section Transitions

- Clean separation with whitespace.
- Avoid waves, decorative dividers, and unnecessary shapes.

Signature Layouts

- Important sections may intentionally break the standard grid.
- This is reserved for major moments such as Hero, MTC, and key campaigns.
- Grid-breaking must remain elegant and consistent with CLA.

Forms

- Contact, Prayer Request, Give, Registration, and other forms are presented inside premium cards.

Desktop Layout

- Primarily two-column.
- One-column layouts are used where they improve readability.
- Three-column layouts are allowed when they improve organization.

Mobile Layout

- Single-column by default.
- Two-column layouts are allowed when readability, touch targets, and accessibility remain excellent.
- Mobile must never feel like a collapsed desktop page.

White Space

- White space is a design element.
- It creates elegance, focus, clarity, rhythm, and hierarchy.
- Empty space is not wasted space.

Section 7 - Cards

STATUS: APPROVED

Card Style

- Premium, elegant, and minimal.
- Handcrafted, modern, and refined.
- Every card belongs to one CLA component system.

Card Backgrounds

- Mixed depending on the page.
- White is the default.
- Tinted, dark, or accent-colored cards are allowed when intentional.

Card Shadows

- Subtle and consistent.
- Shadows create depth rather than decoration.

Card Borders

- Thin and subtle.
- Borders define cards without feeling heavy.

Corner Radius

- Cards use the shared official radius system.
- Arbitrary card-specific radii are not allowed.

Glassmorphism

- Allowed only for special premium moments.
- It is never the default visual language.

Card Content

- Minimal content with one clear purpose.
- Avoid unrelated information inside one card.

Interactions

- Cards are interactive when appropriate.
- Use smooth lift, subtle elevation, and elegant transitions.
- Motion supports usability, not entertainment.

Card Images

- Images may be edge-to-edge or contained depending on the card type.
- The choice must be intentional and consistent with CLA.

CTA

- One clear primary CTA per card.
- Avoid multiple competing actions.

Card Height

- Cards in the same grid should maintain equal height whenever practical.
- Exceptions are allowed only when content would become unreadable.

Icons

- Icons are encouraged when they improve understanding.
- Icons must never be emojis.
- Icons should be elegant, minimal, professional, timeless, and preferably outline or cutout style.
- Cartoon-like icons are not allowed outside intentionally designed children's experiences.

Section 8 - Radius & Shadows

STATUS: APPROVED

Corner Radius System

- Small - 12px: input fields, badges, chips, small utility components.
- Medium - 20px: buttons, small cards, navigation elements, secondary components.
- Large - 28px: hero images, featured cards, major content sections, videos, gallery items.

Radius Rules

- Only these three radius values are allowed.
- Components of the same type must always use the same radius.
- Buttons, cards, images, forms, dialogs, and all UI components share the same system.
- Hero sections also use the 28px radius.

Shadow System

- One subtle neutral shadow is the official default shadow.
- Shadows create depth, never decoration.
- Large dramatic shadows are discouraged.
- All elevated components use the same base shadow.

Hover Elevation

- Interactive components subtly lift on hover.
- Shadow may increase slightly.
- Motion remains smooth and premium.

Colored Shadows

- Neutral shadows are the default.
- Royal Blue or Gold shadows may be used only for signature premium moments.
- Colored shadows must remain subtle.

Focus and Selected State

- Focused or selected components use a subtle Royal Blue outline and subtle shadow increase.
- The state must be clearly visible and accessible.

Universal Rule

- Every visible UI component follows the official radius and shadow system.
- Flat custom-styled components outside the system are not permitted.

Section 9 - Motion & Animations

STATUS: APPROVED

Overall Motion Style

- Smooth, elegant, and premium.
- Motion communicates craftsmanship.
- No abrupt or distracting transitions.

Page Transitions

- Smooth slide and fade transitions.
- Fluid, natural, and consistent.

Hover Animations

- Subtle lift.
- 1-2% scale increase.
- Gentle color transition.
- Slight shadow increase.

Scroll Reveal

- Gentle fade-in only.
- No bouncing, sliding, or exaggerated entrance effects.

Button Interactions

- Animate on hover and click.
- Hover may lift and increase shadow slightly.
- Click uses a brief press animation and immediate visual feedback.

Loading Experience

- Elegant skeleton loaders and subtle fades.
- Avoid traditional spinning loaders whenever possible.

Background Motion

- Extremely subtle animated gradients and ambient movement are allowed.
- If the movement is easily noticeable, it is too strong.

Image Hover Effects

- Subtle 1-2% zoom.
- Smooth transition.
- Optional slight shadow increase.

Navigation Motion

- Smooth fade and slide animations for desktop menus, dropdowns, mobile menu, search panels, and related navigation.
- Motion must never slow navigation.

Reduce Motion

- Respect the user's Reduce Motion preference.
- Reduce or disable non-essential animation when enabled.

Shared Motion System

- One shared animation timing and easing system across the website.
- Components do not introduce unrelated animation styles.

Video Behavior

- Videos never autoplay.
- Visitors choose when playback begins.

Section 10 - Mobile-First Design

STATUS: APPROVED

Design Workflow

- Desktop and mobile are equal priorities.
- Neither may suffer to improve the other.
- Every page is intentionally designed for mobile, tablet, and desktop.
- Every breakpoint is a first-class experience.

Mobile Navigation

- Hamburger menu with a full-screen overlay.
- Smooth opening and closing.
- Easy one-handed navigation.
- Clear hierarchy and large touch targets.

Navigation Depth

- Important pages should be reachable in one tap whenever practical.
- Deep navigation structures should be avoided.

Touch Targets

- Buttons and interactive elements must be large and thumb-friendly.
- Comfortable spacing between controls is required.

Mobile Photography

- Images are optimized individually for mobile.
- Mobile may use different crops, aspect ratios, positioning, or layouts.
- Every important image must be reviewed on mobile.

Mobile Card Layout

- Use a balanced mix depending on content.
- One card per row for reading-heavy content.
- Two cards per row only when readability and touch targets remain excellent.

Mobile Typography

- Typography scales proportionally from desktop.
- Readability always takes priority.
- The same hierarchy must remain clear on smaller screens.

Mobile Forms

- All forms are single-column on mobile.

Sticky Elements

- No sticky navigation, floating buttons, or persistent CTAs by default in Version 1.
- Sticky UI may be reconsidered only with explicit approval and clear usability evidence.

Mobile Spacing

- Slightly reduced compared with desktop.
- The same visual rhythm must be preserved.

Testing

- Every page must be tested in mobile portrait, mobile landscape, tablet portrait, tablet landscape, and desktop.

Performance

- Fast loading and smooth scrolling take priority over decorative effects.
- Optimize images, animations, and interactions.
- A beautiful website must also be fast.

Section 11 - Accessibility

STATUS: APPROVED

Accessibility Philosophy

- Accessibility is built into every component from the beginning.
- It is never treated as a final checklist or afterthought.

Color Contrast

- All text and interactive elements must meet WCAG accessibility guidelines.
- Readability takes priority over decorative design.

Typography

- Text should be comfortably readable by default.
- Use larger text whenever practical.
- Readability takes priority over fitting more content.

Keyboard Focus

- Every interactive element has a clear visible focus indicator.
- Use the approved Royal Blue focus outline and subtle shadow.

Images

- Every meaningful image includes descriptive alt text.
- Decorative images use empty alt text.

Videos

- Captions are optional in Version 1.
- This may be revisited in a future version.

Forms

- Validation errors use both color and clear explanatory text.
- Users are never required to rely on color alone.

Links

- Links are identifiable through color, hover state, and context.
- Color alone is not sufficient.

Keyboard Navigation

- The entire website must work without a mouse.
- Support Tab, Shift+Tab, Enter, Space, and Escape where applicable.
- Focus order must be logical and predictable.

Testing

- Accessibility is verified on every page before release.
- Testing occurs on desktop, tablet, and mobile.

Browser Zoom

- The website must remain fully usable at up to 200% zoom.
- Layouts must not break.
- Text and navigation must remain usable.

Accessibility Policy

- Accessibility is the default required best practice.
- Rare exceptions may be made only with explicit approval.
- Exceptions must be documented and never become normal practice.

Section 12 - Page Identity & Variation

STATUS: APPROVED

Page Identity

- Every page has its own personality while clearly belonging to CLA.
- Variety comes from composition and storytelling, not a new design language.

Page Variation

- Identity is created through photography and layout.
- Color remains within the CLA color system.
- Every page feels fresh while remaining unmistakably CLA.

Hero System

- Every page has a unique hero.
- All heroes share CLA typography, colors, spacing, radius, shadows, and motion.

Feature Sections

- Each feature section is designed for its purpose.
- All sections reuse the CLA component library.
- No section introduces an independent design language.

Layout Rhythm

- Pages intentionally vary layouts to create rhythm.
- Alternating image positions and editorial compositions are encouraged.
- Rhythm comes from layout rather than random colors or components.

Signature Moments

- Every major page contains one signature section.
- It becomes the visual highlight of the page.
- One memorable moment is preferred over many competing moments.

Ministry Identity

- Each ministry may have its own accent color within the CLA system.
- Ministries never become separate brands.

New Components

- Pages may introduce new custom components when they genuinely improve the website.
- New components must use CLA typography, spacing, radius, shadows, motion, and colors.
- Approved components become part of the evolving component library.

Component Variation

- Repeated components may have subtle page-specific variations.
- Allowed variation includes photography, layout, accent color, arrangement, and scale.
- Typography, radius, shadows, motion, and craftsmanship remain consistent.

Background Treatments

- Pages may use subtle gradients, warm neutral backgrounds, soft textures, image-backed sections, and editorial compositions.
- Backgrounds support the story and never overpower content.

Default Page Hierarchy

- Hero.
- Signature Section.
- Supporting Content Sections.
- Primary CTA.
- Footer.

Universal CTA

- Every major page ends with a consistent CLA CTA section.
- The CTA should naturally fit the page and not feel like an advertisement.
- Examples include Plan Your Visit, Join Us This Sunday, Contact Us, Watch a Sermon, Learn More, and Give.

Next Section

Section 13 - Seasonal & Event Design (Not yet completed)